Water/Wastewater Industry Career Inventory

According to the EPA (and most everyone in the water/wastewater industry), there is a significant shortage of people heading into careers in the water and wastewater industry. Currently, the median age for water/wastewater operators is about 50 years old. Having looked through a few of the online career/occupation inventories, it appears that careers in water and wastewater – or even careers in utilities with municipalities – are seldom mentioned as far as modern career clusters are concerned. Luckily, the US Bureau of Labor Statistics (USBLS) maintains an online publication, the Occupational Outlook Handbook, which is updated annually and lists just about any occupation you can think of, and anything you might want to know about water and wastewater careers or related careers can be found there.

Interestingly, according to the USBLS, the job outlook for water/wastewater operators is expected to decline from 2020-2030 by 3%, which appears to be in direct conflict with the EPA's outlook that this same industry is experiencing a serious shortage of career employees. Both outlooks are based on solid data, and both are true – so how can this career field be shrinking while also being in dire need of more workers?

Your mission, should you accept it, is to figure out the answer to the above question while also determining if a career in water/wastewater or a water-related career is right for you.

Careers in Water/Wastewater and closely related Fields:

- Water Operators/Technicians
- Wastewater Operators/Technicians
- Onsite Wastewater System Operators/Technicians (for Decentralized Systems)
- Laboratory Scientists/Technicians
- Heavy Equipment Operators
- Office Managers
- Accountants/Bookkeepers
- Information Technology Specialist
- Media/Communication Specialist
- Civil Engineers
- Environmental Engineers
- Global Positioning System (GPS) Field Technician
- Geographic Information System (GIS) Specialists/Analysts
- Source Water Protection Specialists

1. Using the above-listed careers, choose three and write their names in the table on the back of this sheet.
2. Using the USBLS website, research each of the careers to answer the questions in the table.
3. Finish the inventory by answering the questions after the table.

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Career Element	Career Option 1	Career Option 2	Career Option 3
Name of the Career			
Required education?			
Physical activity level?			
Interaction with others?			
Expected work week? (work-life balance)			
Income potential? (starting and average)			
Potential for travel?			
Potential for career advancement?			
Potential for growth in the industry?			
Local job availability/ need to relocate?			
Personal interest?			

Given the information you collected, what career is most interesting to you?

Why did you choose that career?

What are the upsides to this career?

What are the downsides to this career?

Based on what you learned today, why is the water/wastewater career field shrinking while also in desperate need of more workers?